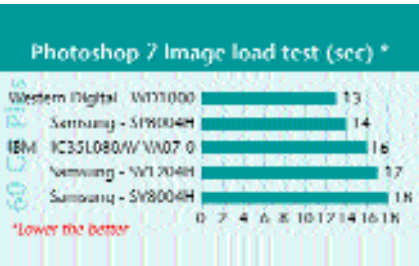


Return to Castle Wolfenstein: We loaded the game on the test hard drive and logged the time taken to load the first map. This test therefore provided a real world indication of the hard disk's performance when running gaming applications.

Here surprisingly there wasn't much of a difference in the performance of the drives. Almost all of the drives took approximately the same time (15 to 16 seconds) to load the game's first map. This was seen in both the categories of the hard disk drives and across spindle speeds and capacities.

Photoshop 7: In this test we recorded the time taken for Photoshop 7 to load, after which a 200 MB TIFF image was opened from the test hard drive and the time taken for Photoshop 7 to open this file was recorded.

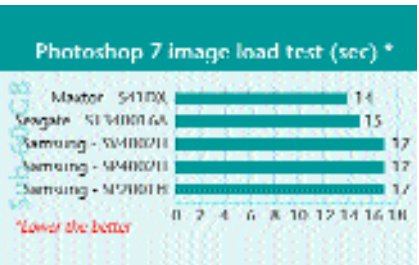


rpm, 20 GB Maxtor 541DX. It executed the test in 14 seconds, which was almost as fast as the best performer in this test in the 60 GB plus category! All other 5400-rpm drives took around 18 seconds to open the file.

Samsung's SV2001H, a 20 GB drive running at 5400-rpm, was the slowest, taking a sluggish 35 seconds to open the 200 MB TIFF image—a consequence of its low sequential read speed. Seagate's 40 GB 5,400-rpm drive (the ST340810A) took 25 seconds to open the image.

Among the 7200-rpm drives Seagate's 40 GB 7,200-rpm ST340016A took 15 seconds whereas, Samsung's drives took around 17 seconds to load the test image.

Over 60 GB capacity: In this category, once again the 100 GB



SP8004H—this 80 GB 7,200-rpm drive took 17 seconds.

The 100 GB Western Digital WD1000 was able to open the 200 MB TIFF file in just 13 seconds, while the Seagate 80 GB 7200-rpm drive took the longest (25 seconds) to open it. The 160 GB drive from Maxtor was a decent performer in the synthetic tests and therefore logged the best application load time which can be attributed to the excellent read burst speed of the drive.

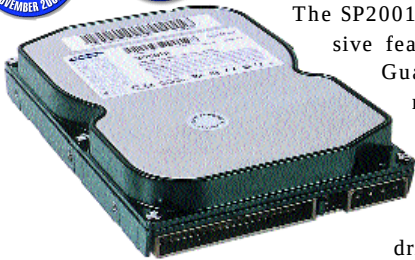
Decision Maker			
	General computing	Professional applications	Entertainment and gaming
You need	To surf the Internet and perform basic tasks such as working with a word processor and spreadsheets	To work with applications such as Photoshop, CAD/CAM software, 3D animation tools	To download MP3s and DivX films and install games, as well as be able to play these without hindrance
Look for	A 20 GB or 40 GB, 5,400-rpm drive	The largest drive you can find, running at 7,200 rpm	A 60 GB plus drive running at 5,400 rpm or 7,200 rpm
Our pick	Samsung SP2001H 20 GB or Maxtor 541DX	Western Digital 100GB or 200 GB drive	Samsung SV0602H or Seagate ST340016A
Price range	Rs 3,750 to Rs 4,500	Rs 10,000 and above	Rs 3,750 to Rs 5,800

Up to 60 GB capacity: All the drives in this category took between 10 to 11 seconds for loading Photoshop. Surprisingly, the drive that managed to open the 200 MB test TIFF file in the minimum time was the 5400-

What it all leads to

Many tests and MBps later, we were left with a set of drives, some of which astounded us with their performance, while others offered value on account of their affordable price. Let's take a look at the winners and see what gave them the edge over the others in the pack.

Up to 60 GB capacity: The Best Performance Award in this category is taken by the Samsung SP2001H. Though it offers only 20 GB space, it posted impressive scores in the synthetic tests and was on target in the real world tests too. It achieved the highest drive index in the SiSoft Sandra test and makes a great buy if you require a speedy drive and do not require too much hard disk space.



The Samsung SP20001H: A great combination of performance and price

The SP2001H also sports impressive features such as Noise-Guard, which ensures low noise levels while running, and technologies such as Impact Guard and SSB that aim to protect the drive from vibrations.

The Best Value Award was also bagged by the Samsung SP2001H. This drive makes a great

buy users looking for a multimedia system and who don't require high disk space. What makes this drive an excellent buy for the 'low is better' user is that it's priced just Rs 250 more than its 5,400-rpm counterpart.

Over 60 GB capacity: The Western Digital WD1000 is undoubtedly our pick for the Best Performance Award in the 60 GB plus category. This drive is your

best option if you require a speedy and high capacity hard drive. With 100 GB of space and 7200-rpm rotational speed, the drive packs enough punch to



Western Digital WD1000: High capacity and speed